How to Build Your Personal Website from Scratch

A Step-by-Step Guide for Non-Technical People

What You'll Need

- A credit card (costs ~$75/year total)
- About 2–3 hours of focused time
- A computer with internet access
- Claude Code (free to start)

Overview: The Three Pieces

Think of your website like a house:

GODADDY
Your Street Address
The domain name, e.g. `yourname.com`

AMAZON LIGHTSAIL
The Land & Building
The server that hosts your files 24/7

CLAUDE CODE
The Architect & Builder
Builds the actual website for you using AI

PART 1

Buy Your Domain on GoDaddy

This reserves your website address so no one else can take it.

1. Go to **godaddy.com**
2. Search for the domain you want (e.g. `yourname.com`)
3. If available, click **Add to Cart** — `.com` is most professional
4. **Skip all upsells** — you don't need website builder, email, etc.
5. Create an account and complete checkout (~$12–20/year)

> **Tip:** Save your GoDaddy login credentials somewhere safe — you'll need them in Part 5.

PART 2

Set Up Your Server on Amazon Lightsail

This rents a small computer on the internet that will serve your website 24/7.

Step 2a — Create an AWS Account

1. Go to **aws.amazon.com** and click **Create an AWS Account**
2. Follow the prompts — you'll need a credit card
3. Once logged in, search for **Lightsail** in the search bar at the top

Step 2b — Create a Lightsail Instance (your server)

1. Click **Create instance**
2. **Select a Region** — choose the one closest to your audience (e.g. US East)
3. Under "Select a blueprint," choose **OS Only → Ubuntu 22.04 LTS**
4. Choose the **$5/month plan** — perfect for a personal site
5. Name your instance something simple like `my-website`
6. Click **Create instance** and wait ~1–2 minutes until a green dot appears

Step 2c — Assign a Static IP Address

> **Important:** Without this, your server's address can change and your domain will stop working.

1. In Lightsail, click **Networking** in the top menu
2. Click **Create static IP** and attach it to your instance
3. **Write down the IP address** — it looks like `54.123.45.67`

PART 3

Build Your Website with Claude Code

Use AI to write your website code — no coding experience needed.

Step 3a — Install Claude Code

1. Go to **claude.ai/code** and follow the installation instructions
2. Open Terminal (Mac: press `Cmd + Space`, type "Terminal," press Enter)
3. Type `claude` and press Enter to start

Step 3b — Describe Your Website

In Claude Code, tell it what you want. Be specific! For example:

> "Create a personal website for me. My name is [Name]. I'm a [your job/role]. Include a home page with a short bio, a page listing my projects, and a contact section with my LinkedIn and email. Make it look clean and professional."

Claude Code will generate all the files you need. Keep asking it to make changes until you're happy — "make the font bigger," "change the color," etc.

PART 4

Upload Your Website to the Server

Step 4a — Connect to Your Server

1. In Lightsail, click on your instance name
2. Click the **Connect** tab
3. Click **Connect using SSH** — a black terminal window opens in your browser

Step 4b — Install a Web Server (nginx)

Paste these commands one at a time into that black terminal window:

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install nginx -y
sudo systemctl start nginx
sudo systemctl enable nginx
```

Step 4c — Upload Your Files

From your own computer's Terminal, run this command (replace the placeholders):

```
scp -i ~/.ssh/your-key.pem /path/to/your/website/* ubuntu@YOUR.IP.ADDRESS:/var/www/html/
```

> **Not sure about the key file?** In Lightsail go to **Account → SSH Keys** to download it. Or ask Claude Code: "How do I upload my website files to my Lightsail server at IP [your IP]?"

PART 5

Connect Your GoDaddy Domain to Your Server

Step 5a — Update DNS Settings in GoDaddy

1. Log into **godaddy.com** → click your name → **My Products**
2. Find your domain and click **DNS**
3. Find the record where **Type = A** and **Name = @** and click Edit
4. Change the **Value** to your Lightsail static IP address
5. Save, then also add a **CNAME** record: Name = `www`, Value = `@`

Step 5b — Wait for DNS to Propagate

DNS changes take **15 minutes to 48 hours** to take effect. Check progress at **dnschecker.org**.

PART 6

Add a Free SSL Certificate (HTTPS)

This adds the padlock icon and makes your site secure — required for Google rankings.

1. Connect to your server again via Lightsail's SSH terminal
2. Run these commands:

```
sudo apt install certbot python3-certbot-nginx -y
sudo certbot --nginx -d yourname.com -d www.yourname.com
```

3. Follow the prompts — enter your email when asked
4. Choose **option 2 (Redirect)** when asked about HTTP → HTTPS

> The certificate renews automatically — you never need to do this again.

You're Live! Visit `https://yourname.com` in your browser — your personal website is now on the internet!

Making Future Updates

1. Open Claude Code and describe what you want to change
2. Claude Code updates your files
3. Re-upload using the `scp` command from Step 4c

Quick Cost Summary

Service	Cost
GoDaddy domain	~$15/year
Amazon Lightsail server	$5/month (~$60/year)
SSL Certificate	FREE
Claude Code	Free tier available
Total	**~$75/year**

Troubleshooting

My domain isn't working yet

Wait up to 48 hours. Check dnschecker.org to see if DNS has updated.

I see the nginx default page instead of my website

Your files may not be in the right folder. They need to be in `/var/www/html/` on the server.

I'm stuck on a step

Open Claude Code and describe exactly where you're stuck — it will help you through it.

I forgot my server IP address

Log into Lightsail — it's listed on your instance dashboard under Networking.

Helpful Links

☁️ **Amazon Lightsail**
Your server dashboard

🌐 **GoDaddy DNS Help**
Official DNS guide

🔍 **DNS Checker**
Check if your domain is live

🤖 **Claude Code**
Build your site with AI

Guide created based on the setup used for **lynnfernando.com**